

## HUGE APPETITE

Prey is very hard to find in the dark zone, so predators must be able to eat almost anything they run into. The amazing gulper eel is one of the most specialized creatures. It has a huge mouth with specially adapted jawbones that allow it to swallow a victim as big as itself. The eel also has an elastic stomach that can expand to hold its outsized meals. The rest of its body has been reduced to a long, slender tail.



### ▲ GULPER EEL

*Since they live at such depths, very few gulper eels have been seen alive. This is a preserved specimen.*

WOW!

The giant squid has the biggest eyes of any known animal. They are up to 11 in (27 cm) across—bigger than soccer balls.

*Tiny eyes on tip of snout*

*Double-hinged jaw enables mouth to open incredibly wide*

*Broad, earlike fins are used to swim through the water*

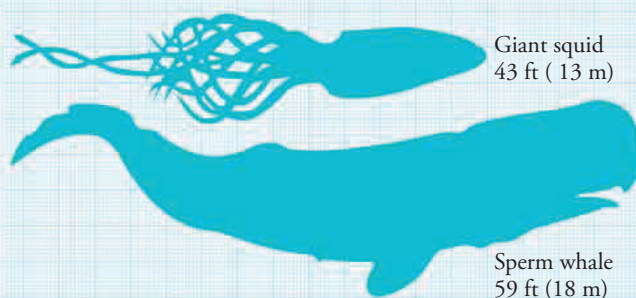
*Sucker-covered arms are used to seize prey*

## JELLYFISH AND OCTOPODS

As well as fish, the open water of the dark zone is home to many other mysterious animals. They include luminous jellyfish, deep-sea squid, and relatives of octopuses called finned octopods. One of these, the small Dumbo octopod, hovers above the ocean floor at incredible depths of up to 13,000 ft (4,000 m). Its big eyes enable it to see luminous prey.

## TITANIC BATTLES

Most dark-zone animals have small bodies so they can survive without having to eat a lot. But a few are colossal. They include the giant squid, which can grow up to 43 ft (13 m) long. It is preyed on by the even more gigantic sperm whale, and defends itself with sharp-toothed suckers on its arms. The squid uses these to rip at the whale's skin, and many sperm whales show the scars.



*Slender body does not need much food, so the fish can survive long spells without eating*

